

Does the claim that God exists outside of time give us
reason to reject premise (2) of the foreknowledge
argument?

It does look like, if Aquinas' view is right, (2) is false. That
is good for the defender of free will.

We'll shortly consider some ways of responding to Edwards' argument. But first let's think about how Edwards' argument might be related to an argument for fatalism.

Suppose that someone did not believe in God — and hence rejected premise (2) of Edwards' argument — but did believe that there were truths about all of our future actions. Could they give an argument similar to Edwards' argument?

There are truths
about our future
actions.

In the past, God
had
foreknowledge of
our future
actions.

To get a grip on this, imagine that one learned of another universe, which had its own system of time and space. And suppose one was given all of the information about everything that ever happens in that universe, and the time at which it happens. So, in particular, you know everything about every free action in that universe. But it's not like you knew of every action **before** that action occurred — you don't exist in the time of that universe.

Let's look again at the premises which make
reference to time.

1. We have no choice about past facts.
2. In the past, God had foreknowledge of our future actions.
3. We have no choice about the fact that God knows that in the future I will perform a certain action. (1,2)

We started off with two arguments for the reality of fate.

The first was the Logical Argument for Fate, which was based on the Law of the Excluded Middle.

The law of the excluded middle

For any proposition P , either P is true or $\text{Not-}P$ is true.

But what if we denied this? Perhaps claims about future free actions — like claims about what you will eat for dinner tonight — are neither true nor false, but simply “undetermined.” They do not now have any truth-value (though they will later).

There are two central objections to open theism.

The second central objection to open theism is more theological than philosophical. And this is just that it is hard to square the view that God does not know what we are going to do with certain features of the main monotheistic religions.

Various passages in both the Old and New Testaments (as well as in the Koran) seem to imply the existence of divine foreknowledge.

Consider, for example the following well-known passage from the Gospel of Matthew, in which Jesus is speaking to Peter:

“Truly, I tell you, this very night,
before the rooster crows, you will
deny me three times.”

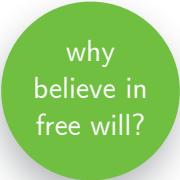
One who denies divine foreknowledge seems forced into saying either that Jesus did not really know what he said to be true, or that Peter's denial was not free.



two
arguments
against free
will



is fate
real?



why
believe in
free will?



three
ways out

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he said to be true, or that Peter's denial was not free.

So now consider a possible scenario in which someone exactly like you would get

that Predict did not **take away** their free will; it just shows them that they

never had any. So they lacked free will before getting a Predictor.

a Predictor. By the above line of thought, this person would lack free will. But

But this person was stipulated to be exactly like you. So you don't have free will,

either.

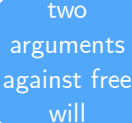
things as fate, then there is no free will.

and the example of the Predictor — which seem to show that if there is such a

So far we've looked at two imaginary thought experiments—the story of Osmo,

Our question is: do either fatigue or foreknowledge pose a

serious challenge to the reality of free will?



two
arguments
against free
will



is fate
real?



why
believe in
free will?



three
ways out

freedom that comes from fate.

Our first topic today is the oldest challenge to the existence of free will: the challenge to

(5) Let's look at what happens if we

with reference to the being of truth about

our future actions.

replace reference to God's foreknowledge

God only shows up in premises (2) and



2* In the past, there were truths about

(3, 4, 5)

choice about the fact that if p , then q ,

then we have the choice about q.



all of our activities.

will perform various actions.

1. We have no direct facts.

5* We have noticed that the fact

perform a certain action (1,2)

that if it is true that I will perform

acaioid.

3 We have not the fact that

God knows that in the future I will

some action, then I will prefer that

0 We have achieved what we

4. If we have no choice about p , and no

The fatalist argument

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